

The North Vietnamese Army

For the North Vietnamese, the war was part of a decades-long struggle to defend their homeland from foreign aggressors—Japanese, French, and American alike—to depose the regime in Saigon, and to unify the nation under the communist leadership of Ho Chi Minh.

◀◀ BEFORE

When Ho Chi Minh declared the Democratic Republic of Vietnam independent from French control in 1945, he understood this to include all of Vietnam.

DREAM DENIED

The **Geneva Accords** promised to make that understanding a political reality through countrywide elections to be held in 1956, but the United States and southern Vietnamese people who did not want to live under communism had other ideas: the creation of an **independent Republic of Vietnam below the 17th parallel**. The vision of an independent, communist Vietnam, which Ho Chi Minh and his followers had been **fighting for**, slipped out of reach.

The Viet Minh agreed to the terms of the 1954 Geneva Accords because they had promised to reunify Vietnam under leadership determined by national elections in 1956, which virtually guaranteed victory for Ho Chi Minh and his movement. Ngo Dinh Diem, president of the newly formed Republic of Vietnam (South Vietnam), did not implement these elections. The politburo of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam (North Vietnam) believed that they had no alternative but to return to war to unify the country.

Patriotic society

However, after eight years of war against France, North Vietnam knew it was not yet strong enough to win against the South. “Build up the north, look to the south” was a key North Vietnamese slogan during this time as they worked to modernize and professionalize the People’s Army of Vietnam (North Vietnamese Army, or NVA). New ranks and a formal order of command were created, making the NVA more reflective of modern Western armies, and the NVA also acquired weapons from China and the Soviet Union. Tanks and aircraft from these allies allowed the NVA to form artillery and air force units, but the army continued to use the majority of its men in infantry units.